# Week 2 Notes: Tin Pan Alley, Early Jazz, Hillbilly and Race Music

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Music becomes popular — how the industry built the categories. Reconstructed from the Week 2.1, 2.2 and 2.3 slides; no lecture recording.

## The Week's Question

**How did distinct sounds and styles become developed by artists *and* the recording industry?**

That "and" is the whole week. Hillbilly, race music, jazz and the blues are not just musical styles that existed and then got recorded — they are categories the industry built, named, renamed, and sold. This is Frith's Week 1 argument put to work on actual cases.

**Writing about music** (Week 2.1, setting up the annotated playlist assignment):

> "The best of popular music writing challenges us to move beyond our own ears, beyond our **assumed categories**, listening practices and [playlists]" (Brabazon 36)

> Hard to write without "falling back to the default setting of lyrical analysis, political resistance and masculine authenticity" (Brabazon 40)

The second quote is the practical warning for the assignment: the easy essay analyses the lyrics, calls the song resistant, and treats a male rock performer as the authentic case. Push against all three — write about rhythm, voice, production, and circulation instead.

## Tin Pan Alley (late 1800s onward)

**Music publishers at the centre of the music business.** Before records, the industry sold *paper*. Broadway and vaudeville relied on Tin Pan Alley for material.

**The economics of circulation**

- Middle-class **home entertainment** is the market
- **The piano** is the delivery device — **45,000 pianos manufactured in 1880**

- **Sheet music: 30–40 cents a copy**

That combination explains the whole model: if a household owns a piano, a hit is a song people buy to play themselves. The "consumer" is a performer.

**American popular music versus established taste** (European opera). Tin Pan Alley is where an *American* popular music gets defined against a European high-culture standard — the high/low argument from Week 1, in its first concrete form.

**Songwriting and structure: homogenization and standardization.** Songs are built to a repeatable formula, because a formula is what a publishing business can produce at volume.

**An "American" sound** — one that **reflected multiple ethnicities in Tin Pan Alley, namely Jewish American, Irish American, and African American**. Worth holding alongside the appropriation material later in the week: the same industry that mixed these traditions also sorted performers by race into separate record series.

## Irving Berlin

**Born Israel Baline, Russia, 1888. New York, 1893.** The immigrant trajectory is part of the "American sound" point above.

**Collaboration is central to the Tin Pan Alley mode of production**, in three steps:

1. **Collaborative oral creation**
2. **Capture in musical notation**
3. **Published sheet music**

This is the model Chuck Berry is set against in Week 4 — Berry writes, sings, and plays his own songs; Tin Pan Alley separates those roles and works behind the scenes.

**The song form.** Berlin's songs *often* include:

1. Piano introduction
2. **Vamp** (two or four bars)
3. Two (or more) **verses** (sixteen or thirty-two bars)
4. **Chorus**

Example: "You'd Be Surprised" — written by Berlin, performed on record by Billy Murray (OKeh). The midterm review sheet lists it under Murray's name.

**"Alexander's Ragtime Band" (1911)**

- **Emma Carus** (vaudeville) helped popularise the song — note that a performer, not the writer, does the popularising
- 1911: Victor Military Band version
- 1958: Ella Fitzgerald version

The 47-year gap between those two recordings is itself the Week 1 point about music "gaining new audiences, meanings and contexts."

Also from this unit: **George Evans, "In the Good Old Summer Time" (1902)**, heard in the Haydn Quartet and orchestra recording of 1903.

## After Sheet Music

**1920s: new technologies for music consumers, which would revolutionize the music and recording industries.** The phonograph moves the product from paper you play to a recording you listen to. Edison's slogan on the slides — *"I want to see a Phonograph in every American Home"* — is the ambition stated plainly.

**1909: a new Copyright Act.** Royalty fees from recorded music, called **"mechanicals"** — from "mechanical reproduction." Remember this term: it is the legal machinery that makes recorded music a business, and it is why copyright keeps mattering later (traditional spirituals being copyright-free is what lets Ray Charles adapt them in Week 3).

**The economic shape of the era**

| Year | Recorded-music revenue | Context |
|---|---|---|
| 1921 | $106 million | Peak |
| 1933 | $6 million | Low — radio's popularity plus the Great Depression |

A roughly 94% collapse in twelve years. Two causes, and note they pull in opposite directions: **radio** competes by giving music away free, and the **Depression** removes disposable income.

**Classification.** The industry sorted records into:

- **"popular"**
- **"classical" or "serious"**

And "popular" included **jazz (music from dance bands)** and **solo singers (vaudeville, crooners, torch singers)**. Here is the Week 1 high/low distinction hardened into a filing system.

## The 1920s: "The Jazz Age"

**Popularization** came through **"syncopated dance music"** played by **high society orchestras**. Jazz was born from a **variety** of musical traditions including **ragtime and blues** — the slides underline "variety" for a reason: no single origin.

**The split that matters**

| | "Hot Jazz" | "Sweet Dance Music" |
|---|---|---|
| How it was made | Oral, improvised | Written |
| Who played it | Small combos | High society orchestras |
| Example | Jelly Roll Morton, "Black Bottom Stomp" (1925/26) | Paul Whiteman's orchestra |

This is the division that decides who gets called a jazz musician and who gets called the King of Jazz.

**Ragtime:** a **syncopated, African American piano music with ties to European marches**. Scott Joplin, **"Maple Leaf Rag" (1899)**. The slides mark this entry with an asterisk: **Tin Pan Alley & *appropriation** — flagging it as the first case of the week's central concept.

## Paul Whiteman, "The King of Jazz"

**1890–1967. American bandleader, composer, violinist.**

Dubbed "King of Jazz" **due to the association between "jazz" and "sweet dance music"** — that is, because the industry had defined jazz as the written, orchestral, white-bandleader version rather than the improvised one. Two consequences the slides name directly:

- **Blending of symphonic music and jazz**
- **Exclusion: African American artists**

**"Hot Lips"** — Paul Whiteman featuring Henry Busse, released/recorded **1922**. Busse was a founding member of the orchestra. **Listen for: recording technology and the relationship to the band** — i.e. how the recording process itself shapes what you hear of the ensemble.

**This is the template.** When Elvis is called "the King of Rock 'n' Roll" in Week 4, the lecture explicitly traces the title back to Whiteman. Same move, thirty years apart: a white performer crowned king of a music initiated and developed by Black musicians. Learning this pair is worth more than either case alone.

## Louis Armstrong and What Got Canonized

The slides return to the 1920s with a pointed heading: music **canonized** as "jazz":

- **Small "hot" combos** (i.e. Louis Armstrong)
- **Ragtime-influenced compositions** (i.e. Jelly Roll Morton)

Note the reversal. At the time, the industry crowned Whiteman and the sweet dance orchestras; the **later canon** rewards the hot combos. Canonization is a second act of selection, performed by critics and historians rather than labels — and it can run opposite to the marketing of the moment. Neither process is neutral.

**Louis Armstrong (1901–1971, New Orleans).** Jazz trumpeter and singer; a major influence in jazz and in **solo performance**; a **distinct voice**.

| Track | Detail |
|---|---|
| "Muskrat Ramble" | Composed by Kid Ory (1926); recorded by Armstrong and the Hot Five (1926); the group's most frequently recorded song — a standard |
| "Stardust" | Composed by Hoagy Carmichael (1927); Armstrong rendition 1931 |

Armstrong returns in Week 3 as an example of **crossover across racial categories**.

## The Swing Era (mid-1930s – early 1940s)

**Large ensembles playing "swing" music.**

**Racial politics**, stated plainly on the slide: **music initially made by and for African Americans, becoming popularized by white bandleaders.** Same structure as the Jazz Age, one decade on.

**Count Basie (1904–1984)**

- From New Jersey; jazz pianist and composer
- Got his start in **Harlem**
- **1935/36:** forms a jazz orchestra

**"One O'Clock Jump" (1937)**

- A jazz standard; a **12-bar blues instrumental**
- The "theme song" of the Count Basie Orchestra
- Reflects Basie's **"riff style"**

Two forward links worth noting. The **12-bar blues** returns as the frame of Chuck Berry's "Maybellene." And the Basie Orchestra's look — a big band with **rotating riffs and solos**, one member standing to solo — is exactly what the Week 4 lecture compares to Little Richard's band in *Don't Knock the Rock*, where members instead leave the formation and climb on the piano.

The swing era's decline is covered in Week 3: rising postwar costs for large bands, and the rise of smaller rock 'n' roll groups.

## Cultural Appropriation

This is the conceptual core of the week, built up over four slides:

**1. The neutral definition.** "The movement of ideas, music, language and identities from one location to another." On its own this is just circulation — what all popular music does.

**2. Cultural imperialism.** "A one-way power relationship of economic and social dominance."

**3. Where the problem is.** "The **political concern** emerges when **empowered** groups take on or take over the attributes of **less powerful** communities." The emphasis is on the slide itself. Appropriation is not movement — it is movement *across a power difference*, in one direction.

**4. The historical pattern.**

> "The history of popular music is punctuated by cycles of **resistance** and **appropriation**"

> "The marketing of music often strips its cultural origin in order to appeal to a larger (and often white) audience"

**Minstrelsy** sits behind all of this — the slides show the "Mr. T. Rice as Jim Crow" illustration. The Week 4 lecture returns to it: minstrelsy and music publishers whose wealth came from slaveholding were not distant history in the 1950s.

**The word "cycles" is the exam-useful part.** It is not one event but a repeating structure, and you can name the turns of the cycle across this course:

| Appropriated from | Popularised as | Era |
|---|---|---|
| African American ragtime | Tin Pan Alley songs | 1900s–10s |
| Hot jazz | Whiteman's "sweet dance music," "King of Jazz" | 1920s |
| Music by and for African Americans | Swing, via white bandleaders | 1930s–40s |
| Race records, R&B, blues | Rock 'n' roll; Elvis as "the King" | 1950s |

## "Hillbilly"

**Hillbilly and race music were categories developed by the music industry** that catered to **rural white Americans** and **African Americans** respectively — and crucially, both **developed outside of Tin Pan Alley**. The publishing machine did not make this music; the record companies went and found it.

**The name.** "Hillbilly" became widely used to describe this music **in the 1930s, beginning in the mid-1920s**. Before that, each label had its own name:

| Label | Term used |
|---|---|
| OKeh | "old time music" |
| Columbia | "old familiar tunes" |

| Label | Term used |
| --- | --- |
| Brunswick | "songs from Dixie" |

Three companies, three names for the same music — proof that the category is a marketing decision, not a musical fact. It then becomes Billboard's "hillbilly" chart in 1939, "American Folk" in 1945, and "Country and Western" in 1949 (Week 3).

**How it was recorded.** "The general practice is to take a recording outfit into the territory where such songs grow" (Brackett). Note the phrasing — songs "grow" there, like a crop to be harvested. **Location recording** is the method.

**Vernon Dalhart, "The Prisoner's Song" (1924)**

- **Cost 7 cents to make, sold millions of copies**
- Marketed as a "hillbilly" song
- One of the best-selling songs of the 1920s
- **"Folk" — of the people**

That cost-to-revenue ratio explains why the industry pursued these markets so energetically.

**The Carter Family, "No Depression in Heaven" (1936)**

- The rural (Appalachian) **experience** of the Great Depression — the slide underlines "experience"
- A major influence on bluegrass, country, rock, and pop
- **Maybelle's "Carter style," thumb picking**

The Carter Family reappears in Week 3 as the model of the small, economical band formation that early Elvis follows.

## "Race" Records

**The single most telling fact in the week.** OKeh Records did **location recordings for both hillbilly and race records** — the same company, the same method, the same equipment. And then:

> **Black artists assigned to the 14000 Race Series, White artists to the 15000 Hillbilly Series**

The categories are not musical. They are a **numbering system sorted by the performer's race**. If you need one example to show that genre is an industry construction, this is it.

**What "race music" covered**, per Brackett: "blues, gospel tunes, piano boogie-woogies, small jazz groups, and the funkier swing bands unknown to the white public." A single commercial category holding several unrelated musical styles — defined by audience, not by sound.

**"A market nobody thought of…"** — the slide's framing of how the industry discovered it. The OKeh advertisement reproduced on the slides markets "Negro Records" as "a booming field discovered, developed and led by OKeh," and openly notes the "growing tendency on the part of white people to hear their favorite 'blues' sung or played by famous colored 'blues' artists." The commercial logic is written on the page.

**The Great Migration** is the demographic engine:

- Movement of African Americans from the South to the North
- **Record companies recognizing this large market**

Concentrated urban Black populations in northern cities meant a reachable, buying audience — which is also why Chicago and Detroit matter later in the course.

## From "Race" to Blues to "Classic" Blues

**Classic Blues: the result of diverse musical influences.** Five strands, per the slides:

- **Vaudeville and popular theatre**
- **Evolution in shouts, field hollers, work songs, call-and-response style**
- **Entertainment + the harsh reality of early blues forms**
- **Professionalism and travelling performance**
- **Many performers were women** (in contrast to country blues)

That last point is worth holding onto. Classic Blues is a women's tradition in a course where the later rock canon is overwhelmingly male — the same erasure that affects Sister Rosetta Tharpe in Week 3.

**Bessie Smith, "Empress of Blues" (1894, Tennessee – 1937)**

**"Down Hearted Blues" (1923)** — Columbia Records; both a **popular hit and a race record**. The significance: **African American artists reaching a national audience for the first time.**

**"Put It Right Here (Or Keep It Out There)" (1928)** — compare the two directly:

- Sounds **more "professional"** than "Down Hearted Blues" (1923)
- Vocals are **"stronger"**
- **Accessible/relatable lyrics**

Five years apart, the same singer, audibly more polished. That is the recording industry's professionalising effect in miniature — the same process that later smooths Patsy Cline's yodel into the Nashville Sound.

## Key Terms

| Term | Definition |
|---|---|
| Tin Pan Alley | The New York music-publishing industry; publishers at the centre of the business, selling sheet music for home pianos |
| Vamp | A short two- or four-bar repeated figure before the verse, in the Berlin song form |
| Mechanicals | Royalties from recorded music, named for "mechanical reproduction"; established by the 1909 Copyright Act |
| Hot jazz | Oral, improvised, small-combo jazz (Jelly Roll Morton, Louis Armstrong) |
| Sweet dance music | Written jazz played by high society orchestras (Whiteman) |
| Ragtime | Syncopated African American piano music with ties to European marches (Joplin, 1899) |
| Riff style | Basie's approach — short repeated figures traded between sections |
| Canonization | Later critical selection of what counts as "jazz" — can run opposite to what the industry promoted at the time |
| Cultural appropriation | Movement of music across a power difference: empowered groups taking on the attributes of less powerful communities |

| Term | Definition |
|---|---|
| Cultural imperialism | A one-way power relationship of economic and social dominance |
| Minstrelsy | 19th-century blackface performance tradition underlying the appropriation cycle |
| Hillbilly | Industry category for music marketed to rural white Americans; earlier called "old time music," "old familiar tunes," "songs from Dixie" |
| Race records | Industry category for music marketed to African Americans — at OKeh, the 14000 series |
| Location recording | Taking recording equipment into the region to record local performers |
| The Great Migration | Movement of African Americans from the South to the North, creating the urban market for race records |
| Classic Blues | Professionalised, vaudeville-influenced blues, largely performed by women (Bessie Smith) |

## Listening List

| Track | Artist | Year | Listen for |
|---|---|---|---|
| "In the Good Old Summer Time" | George Evans; Haydn Quartet & orchestra recording | 1902 / 1903 | Early Tin Pan Alley song reaching record |
| "Alexander's Ragtime Band" | Irving Berlin | 1911 | The Berlin form; compare the Victor Military Band (1911) and Ella Fitzgerald (1958) versions |
| "You'd Be Surprised" | Billy Murray (written by Irving Berlin) | — | Piano intro → vamp → verses → chorus, as a structure you can hear |

| Track | Artist | Year | Listen for |
|---|---|---|---|
| "Maple Leaf Rag" | Scott Joplin | 1899 | Ragtime syncopation; the march ancestry |
| "Black Bottom Stomp" | Jelly Roll Morton | 1925/26 | Hot jazz — small combo, improvised feel |
| "Hot Lips" | Paul Whiteman ft. Henry Busse | 1922 | Recording technology and how it renders the band; sweet dance music |
| "Muskrat Ramble" | Louis Armstrong and His Hot Five | 1926 | Small hot combo; solo performance |
| "Stardust" | Louis Armstrong | 1931 | Armstrong's distinct voice on a Carmichael standard |
| "One O'Clock Jump" | Count Basie | 1937 | 12-bar blues instrumental; riff style; rotating solos |
| "The Prisoner's Song" | Vernon Dalhart | 1924 | What a hillbilly best-seller sounded like |
| "No Depression in Heaven" | The Carter Family | 1936 | Maybelle's Carter-style thumb picking; Depression subject matter |
| "Down Hearted Blues" | Bessie Smith | 1923 | A record that was both a pop hit and a race record |
| "Put It Right Here (Or Keep It Out There)" | Bessie Smith | 1928 | More polished, stronger vocals — compare directly with 1923 |

The built-in comparisons: Whiteman vs Armstrong (sweet vs hot), Dalhart vs Carter Family (hillbilly marketing vs lived experience), Smith 1923 vs 1928 (professionalisation).

## Self-Check

- [ ] Explain the Tin Pan Alley business model — what was being sold, to whom, and why the piano matters
- [ ] List the four parts of the Berlin song form

- [ ] Define "mechanicals" and say what made them necessary
- [ ] Account for the fall from $106 million (1921) to $6 million (1933) — two causes
- [ ] Distinguish hot jazz from sweet dance music on three axes
- [ ] Explain why Paul Whiteman was called "King of Jazz," and connect it to Elvis
- [ ] Explain what "canonized" means here, and why the canon can contradict the industry of the time
- [ ] Give the three-part build of the appropriation argument: movement → imperialism → political concern
- [ ] Name the three labels' pre-1930s terms for hillbilly music, and say what the variation proves
- [ ] State the OKeh 14000/15000 fact and explain why it is the week's clearest evidence
- [ ] Explain the Great Migration's role in creating the race-records market
- [ ] Compare Bessie Smith 1923 vs 1928 and say what changed

*Reconstructed from slides only — examples the instructor added in class are not here.*

## Readings

**Tara Brabazon, *Popular Music: Topics, Trends & Trajectories*** (Sage, 2012) — "Writing About Music," quoted at pp. 36 and 40. This is the critical frame for the annotated playlist assignment introduced in Week 2.1.

**David Brackett, *The Pop, Rock, and Soul Reader*** (Oxford, 2020) — the source of the hillbilly location-recording quote ("take a recording outfit into the territory where such songs grow") and the list of what "race music" included. Both are primary documents from the period, reprinted with context.

**Simon Frith, "The Industrialization of Music"** (Routledge, 2000, pp. 231–238) — Week 1's reading, but this is the week it becomes concrete. Sheet music → phonograph → mechanicals → a few labels sorting music by audience is the history Frith says was "in place" by 1945.

## What Later Lectures Reveal About Week 2 (inferred)

*No recording for this week. These are callbacks from the Week 3 and 4 lectures. Anything not on the Week 2 slides was spoken in class.*

| What the later lecture says | Where | What it tells you about Week 2 |
|---|---|---|
| Minstrelsy, and "music publishers that have built their wealth through the owning of slaves" — "this is still ongoing and present" in the 1950s | Week 4.2 | The Week 2 lecture tied early publishing to **wealth from slavery**. That is **not on the slides** — a spoken point the instructor brought back two weeks later. |
| "King of Rock and Roll…connected back to the way Paul Whiteman was… dubbed the king of jazz" | Week 4.2 | The **Whiteman → Elvis** link is explicit. The "King" naming pattern is a course-level argument, not a one-off. |
| The Count Basie Orchestra — "rotating riffs and solos…one member standing up and doing the solo" | Week 4.2 | The Week 2 lecture probably showed Basie performance footage. **Staging matters**, not just sound. |
| Chuck Berry "versus Tin Pan Alley, this former model, very much about collaboration, behind the scenes work" | Week 4.2 | **Tin Pan Alley's collaborative authorship** is the reference point for later questions about who writes a song. |
| "We talk about how race has been built into categories" | Week 3.3 | Hillbilly/race sorting is the central Week 2 takeaway, carried forward as a given. |
| "We saw a picture…of the Carter [Family], three members…this model of a more economical band" | Week 3.3 | The Carter Family returns as the model of the **small band formation** that early Elvis follows. |
| Louis Armstrong named alongside Ray Charles as crossing "across racial categories" | Week 3.3 | Armstrong is framed through **crossover**, not only as a jazz innovator. |

**Emphasis markers on the slides themselves.** Where there is no recording, the instructor's formatting is evidence. These are underlined, asterisked, or bolded on the Week 2 slides:

- "*appropriation" — asterisked on the ragtime slide, flagging it before the concept is defined
- "**variety**" — underlined in "born from a variety of musical traditions"
- "**canonized**" — underlined on "music canonized as jazz"

- "**political concern**," "**empowered**," "**less powerful**" — all underlined in the appropriation definition
- "**resistance**" and "**appropriation**" — underlined in "cycles of resistance and appropriation"
- "**experience**" — underlined in the Carter Family slide
- "**assumed categories**" — underlined in the Brabazon quote

Every one of those points to the same argument: categories are made, and someone with power does the making.

**Inferred emphasis for the midterm:**

1. The appropriation cycle — movement → imperialism → political concern — with examples across decades
2. OKeh's 14000 / 15000 series as proof that genre was sorted by race
3. Whiteman as "King of Jazz" and its echo in Elvis
4. Hot jazz vs sweet dance music, and canonization reversing the industry's choice
5. Brabazon's "default setting" warning, as a guide for your own writing